

# **Lecture 6: Atmospheres II Clouds, Weather, & Climate**

## **Planetary Systems**

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## Learning objectives

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By the end of this lecture, you will be able to:

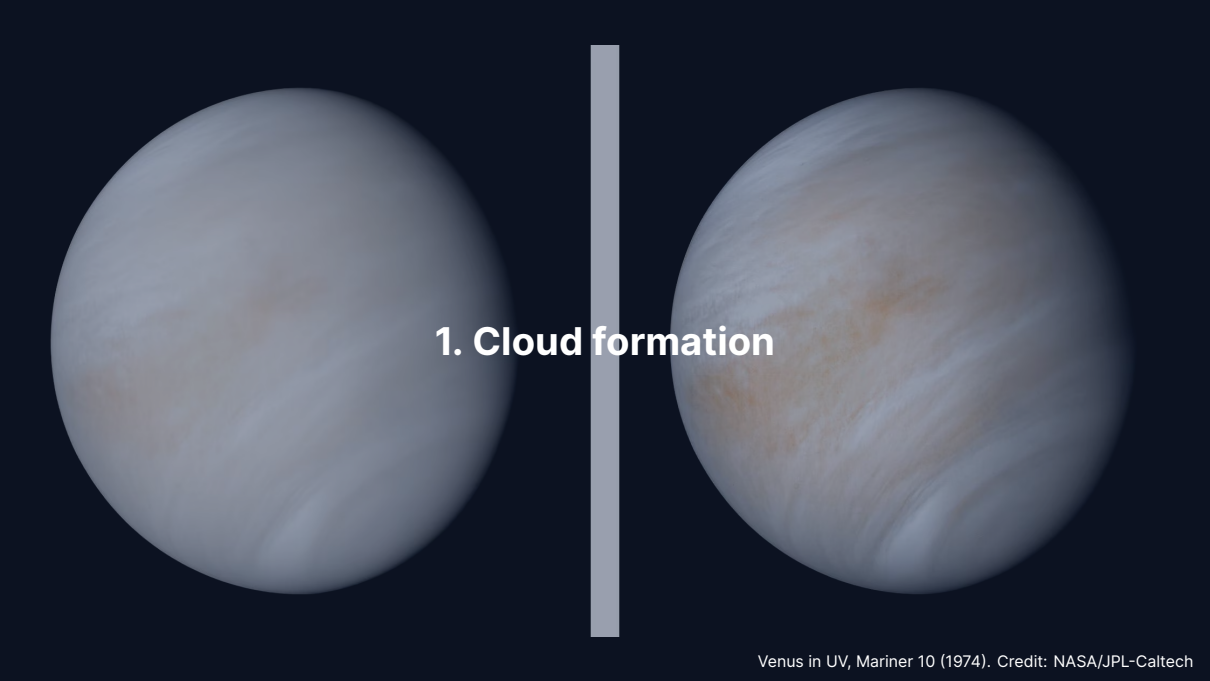
- Derive the Clausius-Clapeyron equation and apply it to predict cloud formation
- Explain atmospheric circulation using the Coriolis effect and geostrophic balance
- Describe weather phenomena throughout the solar system
- Discuss long-term climate evolution, including the faint young Sun paradox
- Explain the carbonate-silicate cycle as a climate thermostat

## Recap: Lecture 5

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- Atmospheric types: primary ( $\text{H}_2/\text{He}$ ), secondary (outgassed), tertiary (modified)
- Hydrostatic equilibrium:  $dP = -\rho g dz$
- Scale height:  $H = k_B T / (\mu m_u g)$
- Radiative equilibrium:  $T_{\text{eq}} = T_{\odot} (R_{\odot} / 2a)^{1/2} (1 - A)^{1/4}$
- Greenhouse effect: surface temperature exceeds equilibrium temperature
- Adiabatic lapse rate:  $\Gamma_d = g / c_p$

**Today:** What happens when vapour condenses? How do winds blow? Why has Earth's climate been stable for 4 Gyr?



# **1. Cloud formation**

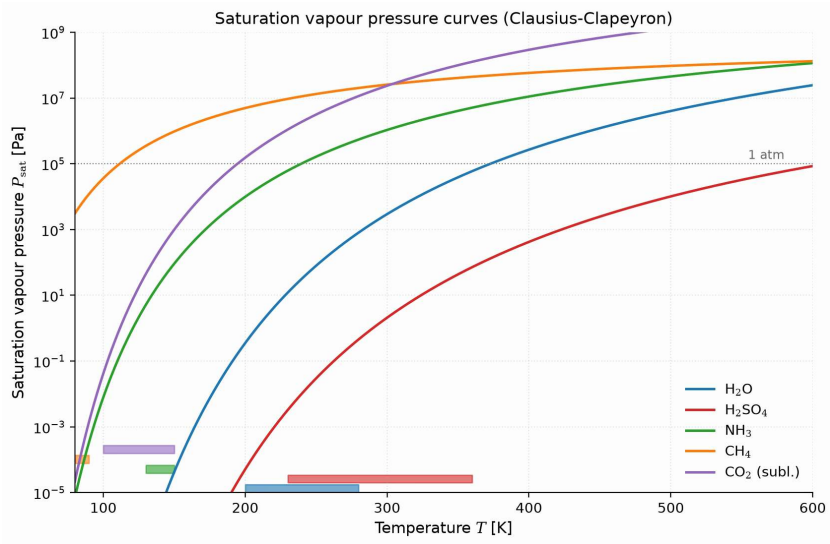
## Saturation and condensation

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- Every vapour has a **saturation vapour pressure**  $P_{\text{sat}}(T)$
- When actual vapour pressure exceeds  $P_{\text{sat}}$ : air is **supersaturated**
- $P_{\text{sat}}(T)$  increases roughly exponentially with temperature
- **Relative humidity:**

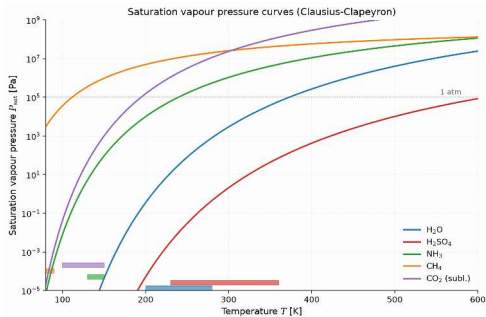
$$\text{RH} = \frac{P_{\text{vapour}}}{P_{\text{sat}}(T)} \times 100\%$$

- RH = 100%: saturated; RH > 100%: condensation can occur
- Rising air cools  $\rightarrow P_{\text{sat}}$  drops  $\rightarrow$  reaches saturation  $\rightarrow$  clouds



Saturation vapour pressure for the five main condensables. Course figure.

# Reading the saturation curves



- Every curve is one Clausius-Clapeyron law: near-exponential rise, steeper for larger  $L_v/R_v$ .
- The lanes at the bottom mark where each species condenses:  $\text{CH}_4$  at 80–90 K on Titan,  $\text{CO}_2$  at 100–150 K on Mars,  $\text{H}_2\text{O}$  at 200–280 K,  $\text{H}_2\text{SO}_4$  across Venus's 230–360 K cloud deck.
- For water, a 20 K cooling cuts  $P_{\text{sat}}$  to a quarter (611 vs. 2360 Pa across 273–293 K): rising air saturates quickly.

A single equation, evaluated per species, predicts every cloud deck in the solar system.

## Nucleation: how droplets form

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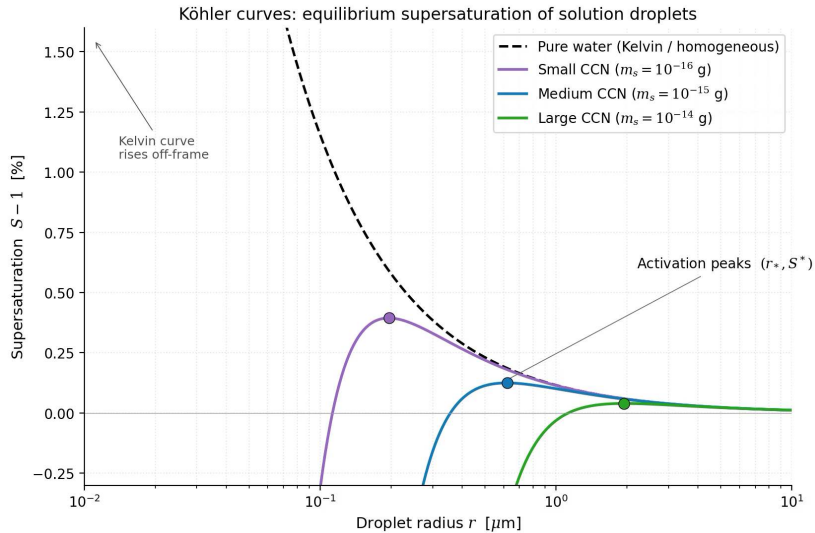
Even in supersaturated air, condensation needs a **seed**.

**Homogeneous nucleation:** Forming droplets from vapour alone  
Requires very high supersaturations ( $RH \gg 100\%$ ), extremely rare

**Heterogeneous nucleation:** Condensation onto pre-existing particles  
**Condensation nuclei:** dust, volcanic aerosols, sea salt, soot  
Activates at only  $\sim 0.04\text{--}0.4\%$  supersaturation: the dominant mechanism

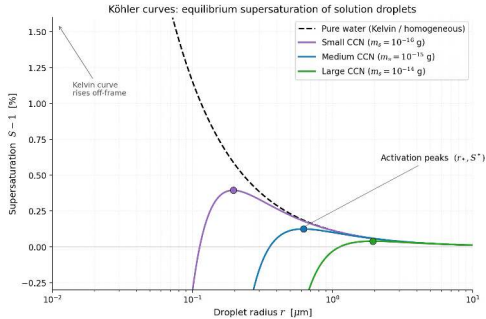
- Earth: oceanic and biogenic nuclei
- Mars: wind-lofted mineral dust
- Giant planets: photochemical hazes from above





Köhler curves: equilibrium supersaturation of solution droplets. Course figure.

# Reading the Köhler curves



- The dashed Kelvin curve is the pure-water barrier: ~12% supersaturation at  $r = 0.01 \mu\text{m}$ , rising further for smaller embryos.
- Dissolved salt (the Raoult term) pulls the curves down: droplets on condensation nuclei activate at peaks of only 0.04–0.4%.
- Past its activation peak a droplet grows freely: the peaks decide which aerosols become cloud droplets.

Real clouds nucleate heterogeneously: aerosols lower the barrier by two orders of magnitude.

## The lifting condensation level (LCL)

- Rising air cools at the dry adiabatic lapse rate  $\Gamma_d = g/c_p$
- Vapour pressure stays roughly constant during ascent
- But  $P_{\text{sat}}(T)$  decreases as temperature drops
- At the altitude where  $P_{\text{vapour}} = P_{\text{sat}}(T)$ : condensation begins

The **lifting condensation level** (LCL) marks the **cloud base**. Above it, latent heat release produces the moist adiabatic lapse rate ( $\sim 5 \text{ K km}^{-1}$  in Earth's warm lower troposphere vs.  $\sim 9.8 \text{ K km}^{-1}$  dry; the observed tropospheric mean is  $\sim 6.5$ ).

Latent heat  $\rightarrow$  buoyancy  $\rightarrow$  vigorous convection  $\rightarrow$  thunderstorms, hurricanes, cumulonimbus.

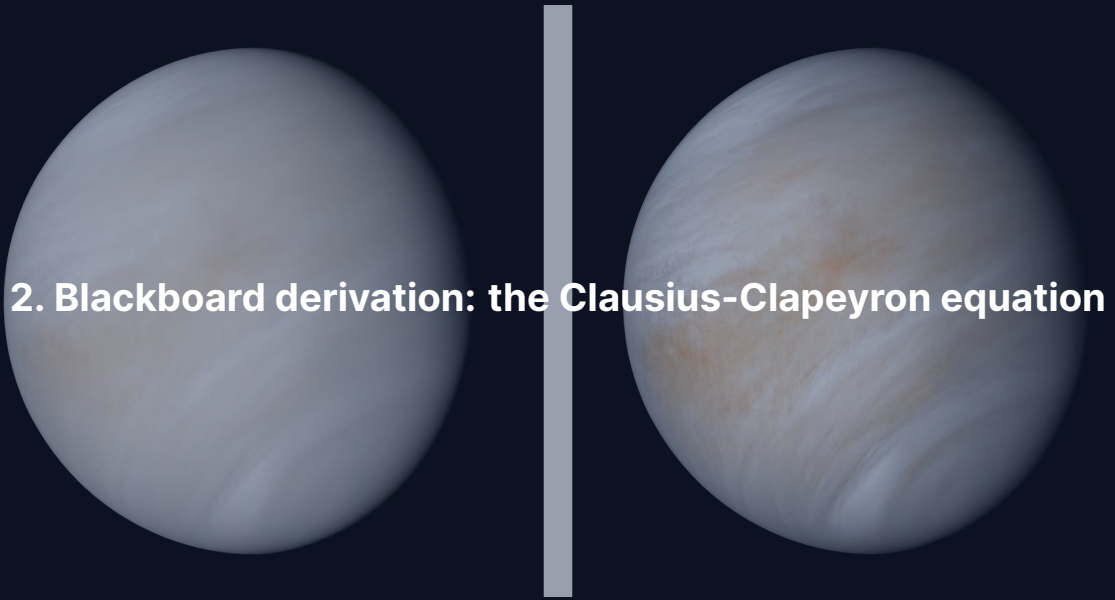
## Cloud types of the solar system

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What condenses depends on temperature and composition:

| Body    | Cloud species                                          | Cloud base altitude |
|---------|--------------------------------------------------------|---------------------|
| Earth   | H <sub>2</sub> O (liquid & ice)                        | ~1–2 km             |
| Venus   | H <sub>2</sub> SO <sub>4</sub> (sulfuric acid)         | ~48 km              |
| Mars    | CO <sub>2</sub> ice, H <sub>2</sub> O ice              | 10–100 km           |
| Titan   | CH <sub>4</sub> , C <sub>2</sub> H <sub>6</sub>        | ~8–30 km            |
| Jupiter | NH <sub>3</sub> , NH <sub>4</sub> SH, H <sub>2</sub> O | layered, 0.5–7 bar  |

The physics is the same everywhere: the **Clausius-Clapeyron equation** governs all of them.



## 2. Blackboard derivation: the Clausius-Clapeyron equation

## Deriving the Clausius-Clapeyron equation

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**Goal:** Derive the exponential dependence of saturation vapour pressure on temperature from thermodynamic phase equilibrium.

**Setup: phase equilibrium.**

Along the coexistence curve, liquid and vapour are in equilibrium:

$$g_\ell(T, P) = g_v(T, P)$$

where  $g$  is the specific Gibbs free energy.

Moving along the coexistence curve by  $(dT, dP)$ :

$$dg_\ell = dg_v$$

## Derivation: the exact Clausius-Clapeyron relation

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From thermodynamics:  $dg = -s dT + v dP$

Setting  $dg_\ell = dg_v$ :

$$(s_v - s_\ell) dT = (v_v - v_\ell) dP$$

$$\frac{dP}{dT} = \frac{\Delta s}{\Delta v} = \frac{L_v}{T(v_v - v_\ell)}$$

**Two approximations:**

1.  $v_v \gg v_\ell$ , so  $v_v - v_\ell \approx v_v$
2. Ideal gas:  $v_v = R_v T / P$ , where  $R_v = R^* / M$

$$\frac{dP_{\text{sat}}}{dT} = \frac{L_v P_{\text{sat}}}{R_v T^2}$$

## Integrating the differential form

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Starting from

$$\frac{dP_{\text{sat}}}{dT} = \frac{L_v P_{\text{sat}}}{R_v T^2}$$

separate variables:

$$\frac{dP_{\text{sat}}}{P_{\text{sat}}} = \frac{L_v}{R_v} \frac{dT}{T^2}$$

Integrate from a reference state  $(T_{\text{ref}}, P_{\text{ref}})$  to  $(T, P_{\text{sat}})$ , assuming  $L_v \approx \text{const.}$ :

$$\ln\left(\frac{P_{\text{sat}}}{P_{\text{ref}}}\right) = -\frac{L_v}{R_v} \left(\frac{1}{T} - \frac{1}{T_{\text{ref}}}\right)$$

Exponentiate to get the integrated form on the next slide.

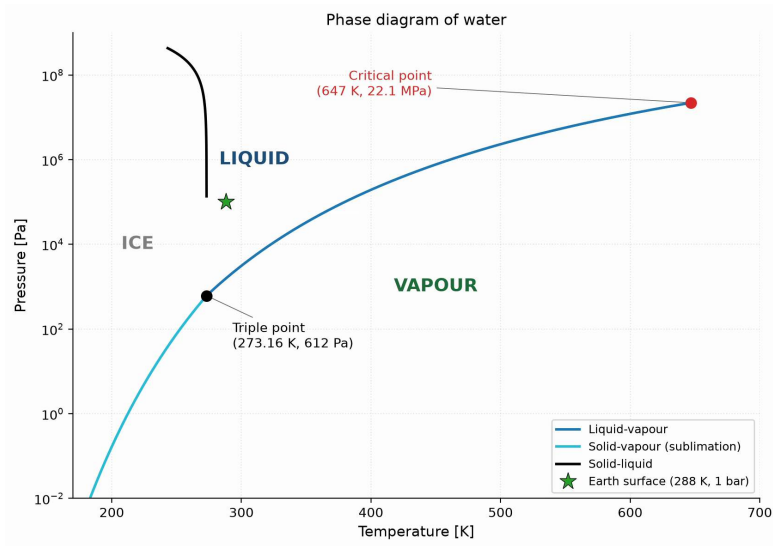


# The Clausius-Clapeyron equation

$$P_{\text{sat}}(T) = P_{\text{ref}} \exp \left[ -\frac{L_v}{R_v} \left( \frac{1}{T} - \frac{1}{T_{\text{ref}}} \right) \right]$$

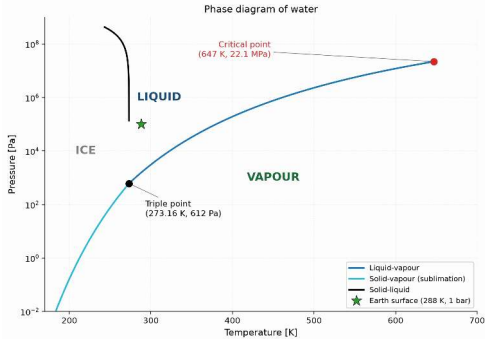
Credit: Derivation follows Catling (2017), *Atmospheric Evolution on Inhabited and Lifeless Worlds*, Ch. 1

- $P_{\text{sat}}$  depends **exponentially** on temperature
- The sensitivity is controlled by  $L_v/R_v$  (units of K)
- Large  $L_v/R_v \rightarrow$  very sensitive to temperature changes
- This equation applies to **any** vapour  $\leftrightarrow$  condensed phase transition



Phase diagram of water. Course figure.

# The phase diagram behind the equation



- The liquid-vapour curve from the triple point (273.16 K, 611 Pa) to the critical point (647 K, 22.1 MPa) is the integrated Clausius-Clapeyron relation.
- The sublimation branch uses the larger latent heat of sublimation: a steeper curve below the triple point.
- Earth's surface sits inside the liquid field; Mars's ~6 mbar surface lies below the triple-point pressure, so liquid water is not stable there today.

Wherever a  $P$ - $T$  profile crosses the blue curve, the equation predicts a cloud, a rain, or a frost.

## Worked example: water on Earth

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For water vapour:

|                                 |                                        |
|---------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| $L_v$                           | $2.50 \times 10^6 \text{ J kg}^{-1}$   |
| $M$                             | $0.018 \text{ kg mol}^{-1}$            |
| $R_v = R^* / M$                 | $462 \text{ J kg}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$ |
| $T_{\text{ref}}$ (triple point) | $273 \text{ K}$                        |
| $P_{\text{ref}}$ (triple point) | $611 \text{ Pa}$                       |
| <hr/>                           |                                        |
| $L_v / R_v$                     | $\approx 5400 \text{ K}$               |

At  $T = 293 \text{ K}$  ( $20^\circ\text{C}$ ):

$$P_{\text{sat}} = 611 \exp\left[-5400\left(\frac{1}{293} - \frac{1}{273}\right)\right] = 611 \times 3.86 \approx 2360 \text{ Pa}$$

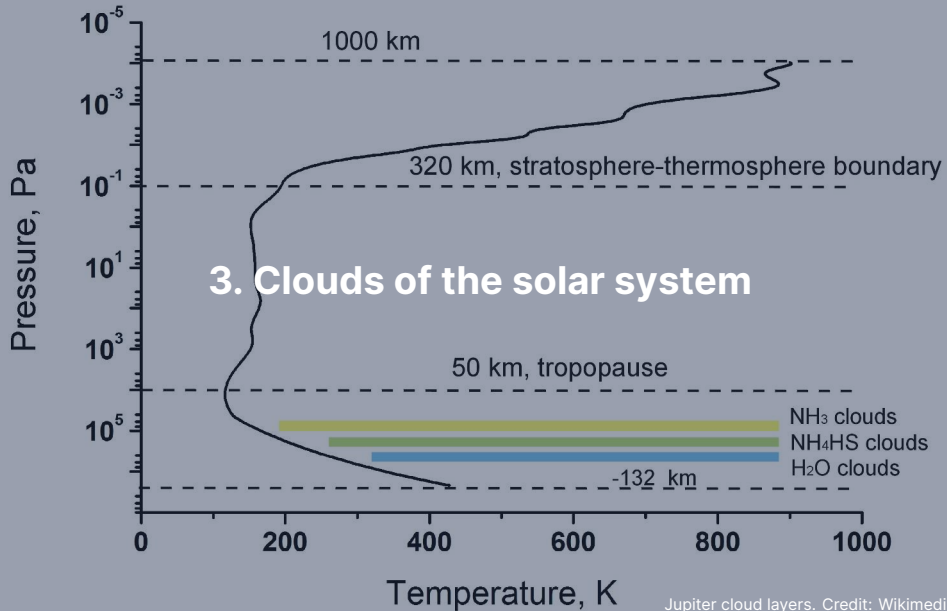
Measured value: 2300 Pa; excellent agreement.

## Condensing species in the solar system

| Species                        | $L_v$ (kJ kg <sup>-1</sup> ) | $R_v$ (J kg <sup>-1</sup> K <sup>-1</sup> ) | $L_v/R_v$ (K) | $T_{\text{cond}}$ (K) | Where                  |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|---------------|-----------------------|------------------------|
| H <sub>2</sub> O               | 2500                         | 462                                         | 5400          | 200–280               | Earth, Mars            |
| H <sub>2</sub> SO <sub>4</sub> | 540                          | 85                                          | 6400          | 230–360               | Venus                  |
| NH <sub>3</sub>                | 1370                         | 488                                         | 2800          | 130–150               | Jupiter, Saturn        |
| CH <sub>4</sub>                | 510                          | 519                                         | 980           | 80–90                 | Titan, Uranus, Neptune |
| CO <sub>2</sub>                | 571                          | 189                                         | 3020          | 100–150               | Mars                   |

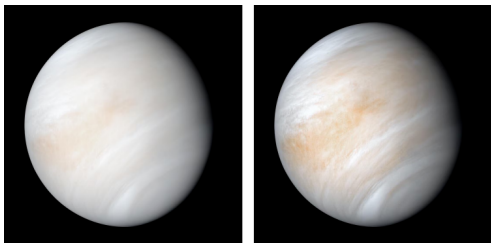
Source: Catling (2017), de Pater & Lissauer (2010);  $T_{\text{cond}}$  is the approximate condensation range at each body's pressure levels

- High  $L_v/R_v$  for H<sub>2</sub>SO<sub>4</sub>: steep saturation curve, sharply defined cloud base on Venus
- Low  $L_v/R_v$  for CH<sub>4</sub>: flat curve, Titan stays near saturation over a wide altitude range



## Venus: sulfuric acid clouds

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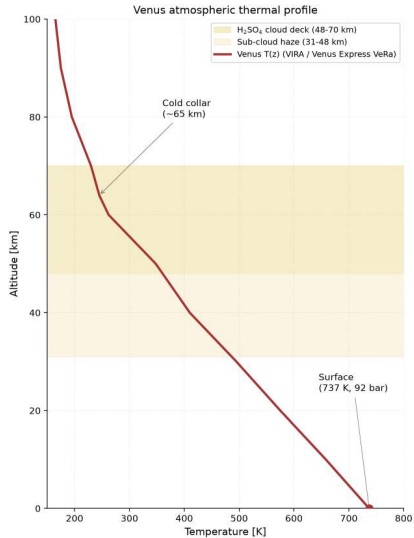


Credit: NASA/JPL-Caltech (1974)

- $\text{H}_2\text{SO}_4$  clouds from 48 to 70 km altitude
- Completely obscure the surface at visible wavelengths
- Photochemistry:



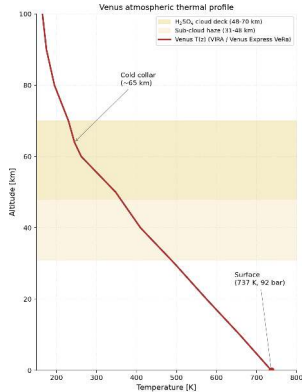
- $\text{SO}_2$  supplied by volcanic outgassing; O from  $\text{CO}_2$  photolysis
- Unidentified **UV absorber** creates banded patterns
- Sub-cloud haze extends down to ~31 km



Venus thermal structure, VIRA / Venus Express VeRa. Course figure.



# Where the Venus clouds live



- The deck occupies 48–70 km, where  $T$  runs from ~360 K at the base to ~230 K at the top: the stability window of concentrated  $\text{H}_2\text{SO}_4$  droplets.
- Below it: a thin haze down to ~31 km, then clear, oven-hot  $\text{CO}_2$  to the 737 K, 92 bar surface.
- The cold-collar inversion near 65 km shapes the cloud top at high latitudes.

The clouds sit where Clausius-Clapeyron allows them: a 22 km deck bounded by evaporation below and photochemical  $\text{H}_2\text{SO}_4$  supply above.

# Mars recurring slope lineae (RSL)

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Credit: NASA/JPL-Caltech/UA/MRO HiRISE

First seen by HiRISE in 2011: narrow dark streaks that grow during the warmest months.

- Found on steep, equator-facing slopes
- Appear in spring/summer, fade in winter
- Length: 50–300 m; width: 0.5–5 m
- **Initial interpretation:** briny water flow (perchlorate salts depress freezing point)
- **Revised view (2017+):** likely **dry granular flow**; spectroscopic water signal re-interpreted
- Still debated: some sites may involve transient liquid brines

## Mars: dust and ice clouds

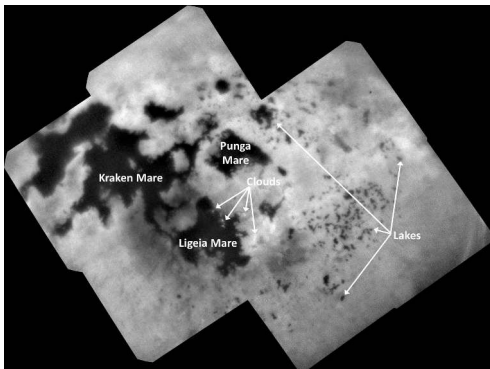
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Mars's thin atmosphere (~6 mbar) supports two cloud types:

- **CO<sub>2</sub> ice clouds:** High altitude (50–100 km); frost point ~148 K at the 6 mbar surface, near 100 K at mesospheric pressures
- **H<sub>2</sub>O ice clouds:** Lower altitude (10–30 km), over Tharsis region, aphelion cloud belt
- **Mineral dust** plays a central role:
  - Condensation nuclei for ice clouds
  - Absorbs solar radiation, heats atmosphere
  - Positive feedback: more dust → more heating → stronger winds → more dust

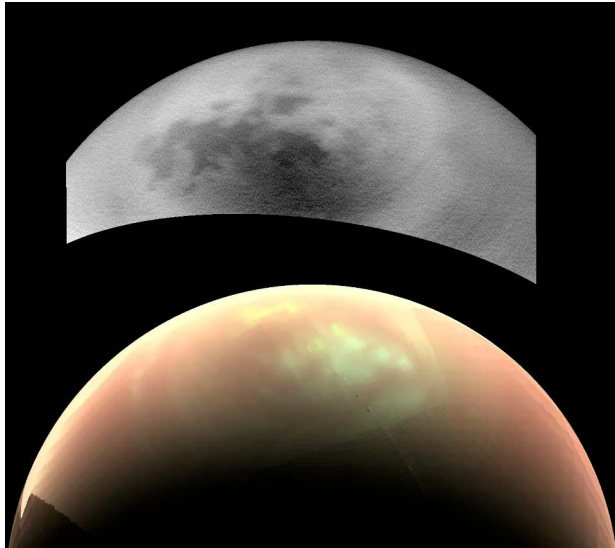
# Titan's methane cycle: an Earthlike analogue

Titan has the only other active hydrological cycle in the solar system, with methane replacing water.



Credit: NASA/JPL-Caltech/ASI/USGS (Cassini)

- **Surface:** liquid methane seas near the north pole
- **Kraken Mare:**  $\sim 400,000 \text{ km}^2$  (Caspian-sized), locally  $>100 \text{ m}$  deep (Hayes 2016; Poggiali et al. 2020)
- Rivers carve channels; methane rain fills lakebeds
- Evaporation at equator, rain at poles
- 30-yr Titan year drives slow seasonal cycling
- Cassini radar mapped lakes; Dragonfly will sample in 2034+



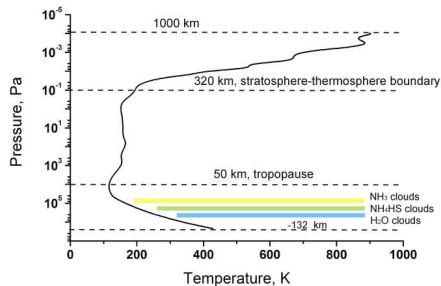
Methane clouds at Titan's mid-southern latitudes, Cassini ISS. Credit: NASA/JPL-Caltech/SSI.

## Titan: methane rain

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- Only known active **hydrological cycle** beyond Earth, with  $\text{CH}_4$  replacing  $\text{H}_2\text{O}$
- Surface:  $T \approx 94 \text{ K}$ ,  $P \approx 1.5 \text{ bar}$ , near the triple point of methane
- Liquid methane: lakes, seas, rivers carved into the icy surface
- $\text{CH}_4$  clouds at 8–30 km;  $\text{C}_2\text{H}_6$  (ethane) clouds also present
- Rainfall infrequent but intense
- Seasonal cloud migration observed by Cassini–Huygens

# Giant planets: layered cloud structure



Credit: Wikimedia, CC BY-SA 3.0

Vertically layered, predicted by  
Clausius-Clapeyron:

1. NH<sub>3</sub> **ice** (top):  $T \sim 130\text{--}150\text{ K}$ ,  $P \sim 0.5\text{--}1\text{ bar}$   
The visible white and coloured bands
2. NH<sub>4</sub>SH:  $T \sim 200\text{--}240\text{ K}$ ,  $P \sim 2\text{--}3\text{ bar}$   
 $\text{NH}_3 + \text{H}_2\text{S} \rightarrow \text{NH}_4\text{SH}$
3. H<sub>2</sub>O **ice/liquid** (deep):  $T \sim 270\text{--}300\text{ K}$ ,  
 $P \sim 5\text{--}7\text{ bar}$   
Drives weather via latent heat release

Ice giants: CH<sub>4</sub> on top, H<sub>2</sub>S below, NH<sub>4</sub>SH and  
H<sub>2</sub>O deeper.

**Break**



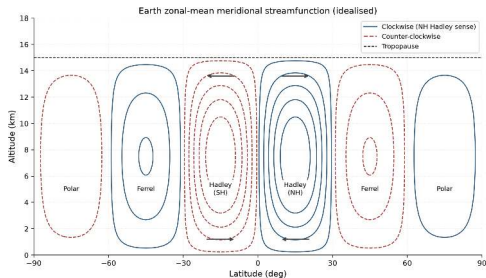




## 4. Atmospheric dynamics

Jet-stream cirrus from orbit. Credit: NASA/JSC

# The Hadley cell

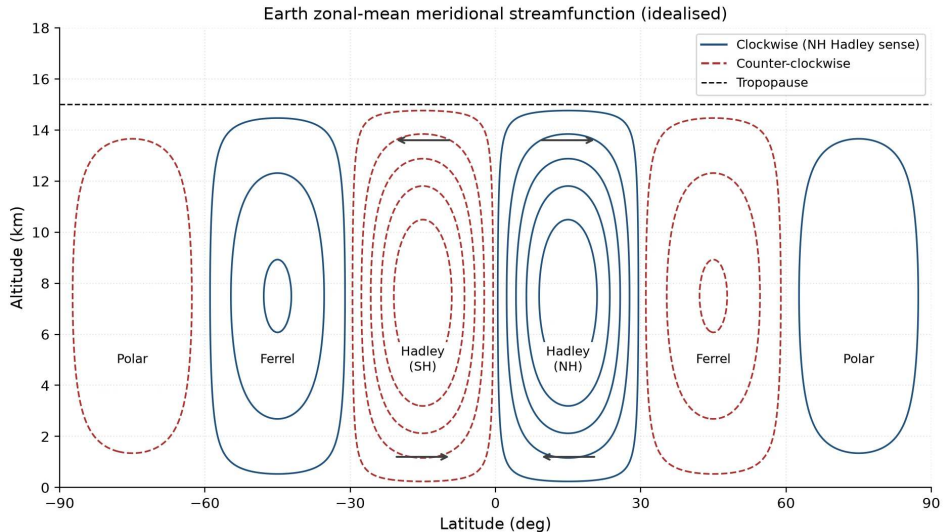


Credit: Course figure

1. Intense solar heating at equator  
→ air rises
2. At altitude, air flows poleward
3. Air cools radiatively, sinks at  $\sim 30^\circ$  latitude
4. Surface return flow → **trade winds**

This loop is the **Hadley cell**:

- Dominant circulation in the tropics
- Primary heat transport: equator  
→ poles
- Sinking zones → desert belts on Earth



Zonal-mean (averaged along latitude circles) overturning circulation of Earth's troposphere.  
Course figure.

## The Coriolis effect

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On a rotating planet, moving air is **deflected**:

- **Right** in the Northern Hemisphere
- **Left** in the Southern Hemisphere

The **Coriolis parameter**:

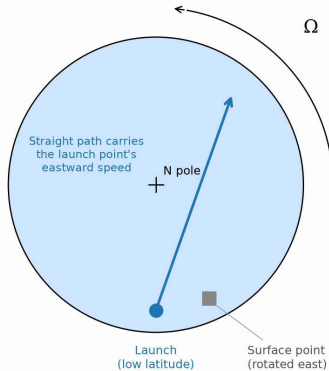
$$f = 2\Omega \sin \phi$$

- Earth:  $\Omega = 7.29 \times 10^{-5} \text{ rad s}^{-1}$  (sidereal)
- At mid-latitudes ( $\phi = 45^\circ$ ):  $f \approx 1.03 \times 10^{-4} \text{ s}^{-1}$
- At equator ( $\phi = 0^\circ$ ):  $f = 0$ , so no Coriolis deflection

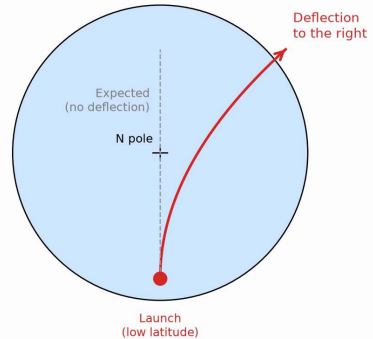
The Coriolis effect explains why winds do not blow directly from high to low pressure, and why weather systems rotate.

Geometric origin of the Coriolis effect (view from above the North Pole)

Inertial (non-rotating) frame:  
parcel travels in a straight line



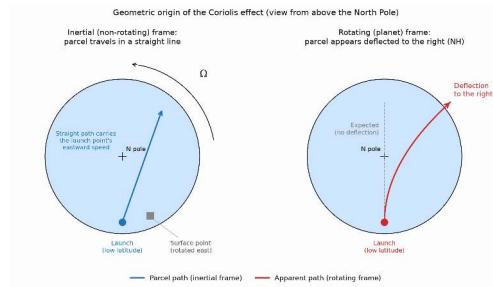
Rotating (planet) frame:  
parcel appears deflected to the right (NH)



— Parcel path (inertial frame) — Apparent path (rotating frame)

The Coriolis effect seen from the inertial and the rotating frame. Course figure.

# Two views of one deflection



- Inertial frame (left): the parcel keeps the eastward speed of its launch point, so its straight path ends up east of the meridian aimed at the pole.
- The ground at higher latitude moves east more slowly: the parcel outruns it.
- Rotating frame (right): the same motion appears as a smooth curve to the right, with strength set by  $f = 2\Omega \sin \phi$ .

No force pushes the parcel sideways. The deflection is the rotating planet turning beneath a straight path.

## The Rossby number

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Does rotation matter for a given flow?

$$Ro = \frac{U}{fL}$$

$Ro \ll 1$ : Rotation dominates: large-scale circulation, jet streams  
Earth:  $U \sim 10 \text{ m s}^{-1}$ ,  $L \sim 1000 \text{ km} \rightarrow Ro \sim 0.1$

$Ro \gg 1$ : Rotation unimportant: tornadoes, dust devils

Determines the number of circulation cells on a planet.

## Circulation cells and rotation rate

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### Slowly rotating (Venus, Titan):

Single Hadley cell from equator to pole in each hemisphere.

Venus: 243-day period  $\rightarrow R_o \gg 1$  for large-scale flows.

### Moderately rotating (Earth):

Hadley cell to  $\sim 30^\circ$ , then Ferrel cell (mid-latitudes), polar cell.

Three cells per hemisphere.

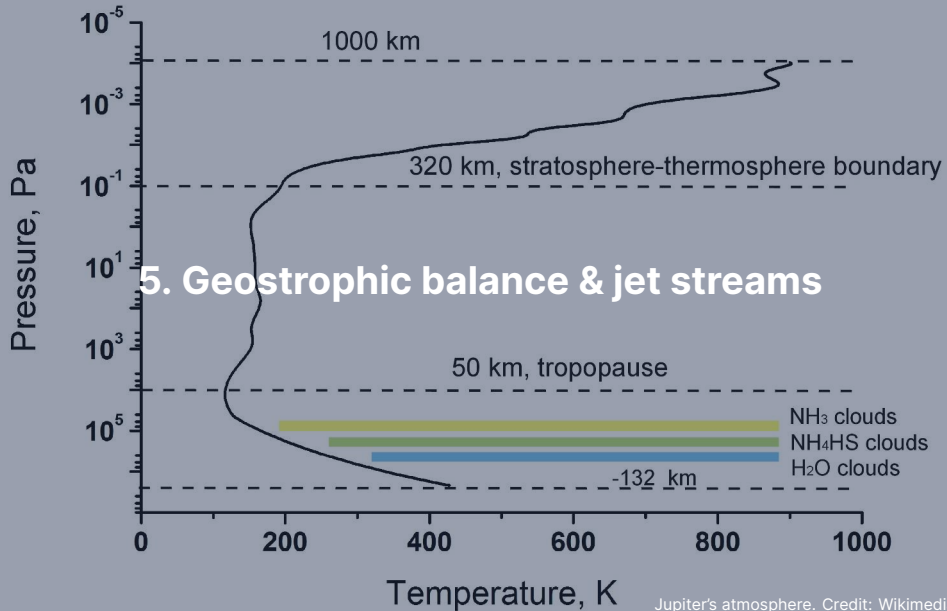
### Rapidly rotating (Jupiter, Saturn):

Many alternating cells  $\rightarrow$  **banded structure**.

Jupiter:  $\sim 15$  alternating jet streams per hemisphere.

Light zones (rising air, high clouds) and dark belts (sinking air).





## Geostrophic balance

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At large scales ( $Ro \ll 1$ ), steady state = Coriolis force balances pressure gradient:

$$f \hat{k} \times \mathbf{v}_g = -\frac{1}{\rho} \nabla P$$

In scalar form:

$$u_g = -\frac{1}{f\rho} \frac{\partial P}{\partial y}, \quad v_g = \frac{1}{f\rho} \frac{\partial P}{\partial x}$$

The geostrophic wind blows **parallel to isobars**, not from high to low pressure. In the Northern Hemisphere: low pressure to the left of the wind.

This is why cyclones and anticyclones **rotate** around pressure centres.

## Jet streams and the thermal wind

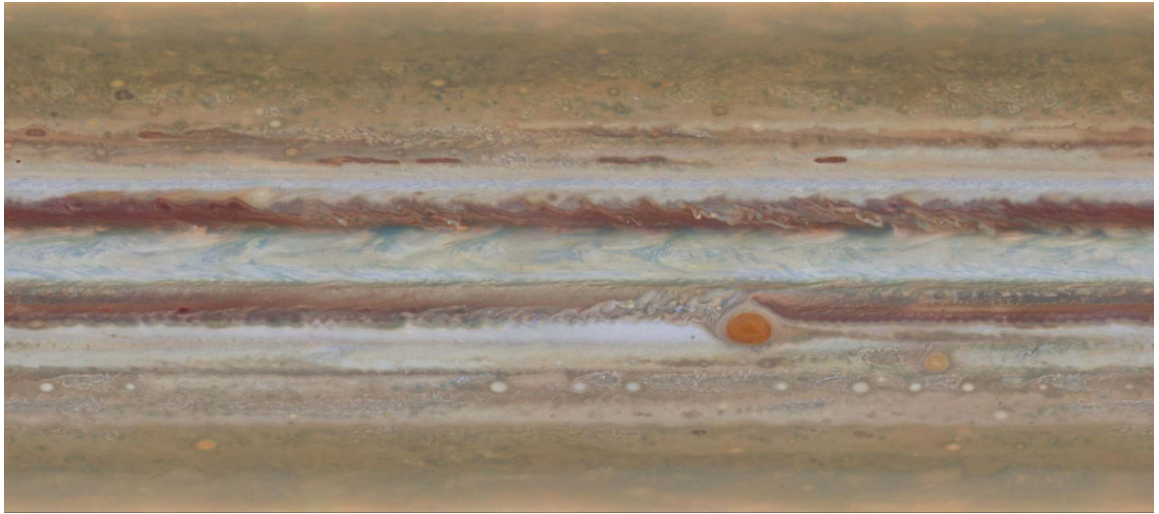
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**Jet streams:** Narrow bands of fast winds ( $\sim 30\text{--}70 \text{ m s}^{-1}$  on Earth).

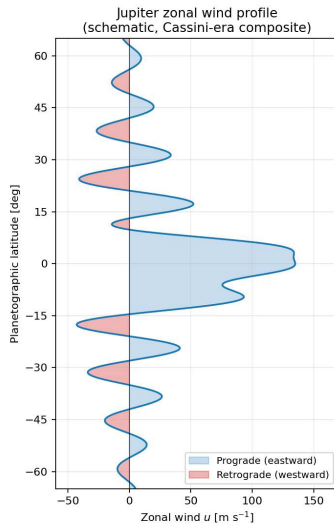
The **thermal wind relation** connects vertical wind shear to horizontal temperature gradients:

$$\frac{\partial \mathbf{v}_g}{\partial z} \propto \hat{k} \times \nabla T$$

- Where  $\nabla T$  is steepest (tropics vs. poles boundary): wind speed increases with altitude
- On Earth: subtropical jet ( $\sim 30^\circ$ ) and polar jet ( $\sim 60^\circ$ )
- Jet streams **steer weather systems** across the planet

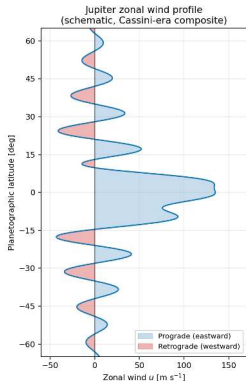


Jupiter's equatorial belts and the Great Red Spot, HST/WFC3. Credit:  
NASA/ESA/STScI/A. Simon.



Jupiter's cloud-top zonal winds, schematic after García Melendo & Sánchez-Lavega (2001).  
Course figure.

# Reading Jupiter's jet ladder



- Alternating prograde (eastward, blue) and retrograde (westward, red) jets stack from the fast eastward equatorial jet out to  $\sim\pm 60^\circ$  latitude.
- The jets sit at the boundaries between bright zones and dark belts; peak speeds reach  $\sim 180 \text{ m s}^{-1}$ .
- Juno gravity data: best-fit e-folding ( $1/e$ -decay) depth  $\sim 1800 \text{ km}$  (range  $1000\text{--}3000 \text{ km}$ ) into the molecular envelope.

How deep do the bands go? Juno's gravity data put the jets thousands of kilometres into the envelope.

## Giant planet banding

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- **Zones** (light): rising air, high clouds (ammonia ice tops)
- **Belts** (dark): sinking air, deeper cloud layers exposed
- Strong **zonal jets** between adjacent bands:
  - Jupiter: peaks of  $\sim 180 \text{ m s}^{-1}$
  - Saturn:  $\sim 400 \text{ m s}^{-1}$
- Jets remarkably stable over decades of observation
- Juno gravity: best-fit decay depth  $\sim 1800 \text{ km}$  into the molecular envelope

The same geostrophic and thermal wind physics that produces Earth's jet streams creates the banded structure of the giant planets, just with many more cells due to rapid rotation.

A close-up, high-resolution image of Jupiter's Great Red Spot, a massive, oval-shaped storm system. The storm is characterized by a reddish-orange center surrounded by swirling white and light brown clouds. The image is presented as a semi-circular arc against a dark blue background.

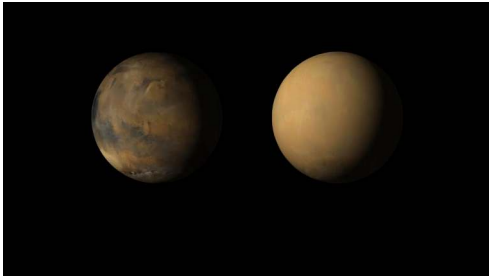
## **6. Weather & storms in the solar system**

Jupiter's Great Red Spot. Credit: NASA/JPL-Caltech/SwRI/MSSS



# Mars: dust storms

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Credit: NASA/JPL-Caltech/MSSS

- Local storms: dust lofted to 10–30 km
- Occasionally grow into **global dust storms**
- 2018 global storm ended *Opportunity's* 15-year mission
- **Positive feedback loop:**  
dust absorbs sunlight → heats air → stronger winds → more dust

## Seasonal CO<sub>2</sub> cycle:

- ~25–30% of atmosphere freezes onto polar caps each winter
- Surface pressure swings: 5–7 mbar

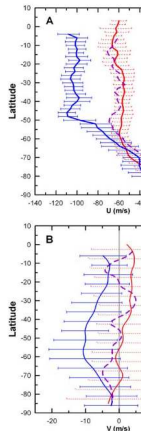
## Venus: super-rotation

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- Venus's surface rotates once every 243 Earth days (retrograde)
- Cloud-top winds:  $\sim 100 \text{ m s}^{-1}$ , circling the planet in  $\sim 4$  days
- Atmosphere rotates **60× faster than the planet**
- This is **atmospheric super-rotation**

### A major puzzle

Super-rotation requires angular momentum transport **upward and equatorward**, against friction. Leading explanation: thermal tides + planetary-scale waves. The detailed mechanism remains an active area of research.



**Figure 2.** Averaged wind profiles hemisphere at cloud level (April 2006). zonal velocity is drawn as a function of using cloud tracers at three wavelength 380 nm; upper cloud, altitude ~ 66 k infrared (violet, 980 nm; upper cloud, all time), and infrared (red, 1.74 μm; low 47 km; night time). (b) The meridional v function of latitude for the same three

Venus cloud-level winds from VIRTIS, Venus Express's imaging spectrometer. Reproduced from Sánchez-Lavega et al. (2008).

# Measuring super-rotation

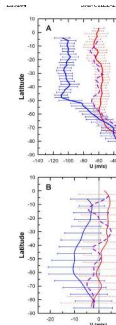


Figure 2. Averaged wind profiles homosphere, at cloud level (April 2006). zonal velocity is drawn as a function of using cloud traces at their wavelength 390 nm, upper cloud, altitude ~ 66 k, infrared (violet, 980 nm, upper cloud, at time), and infrared (red, 1.54  $\mu$ m, low 47 km, night time). (b) The meridional velocity of latitude for the same time.

- Cloud tracking at three wavelengths probes three altitudes: ~66 km and ~61 km by day, ~47 km by night.
- Zonal winds: ~105 m s<sup>-1</sup> at the cloud top, 60–70 m s<sup>-1</sup> at the cloud base: the whole deck super-rotates.
- Meridional winds are ten times weaker, poleward at the top: a slow overturning beneath a fast zonal spin.

The super-rotation extends through the whole cloud deck, 60 times faster than the planet beneath.

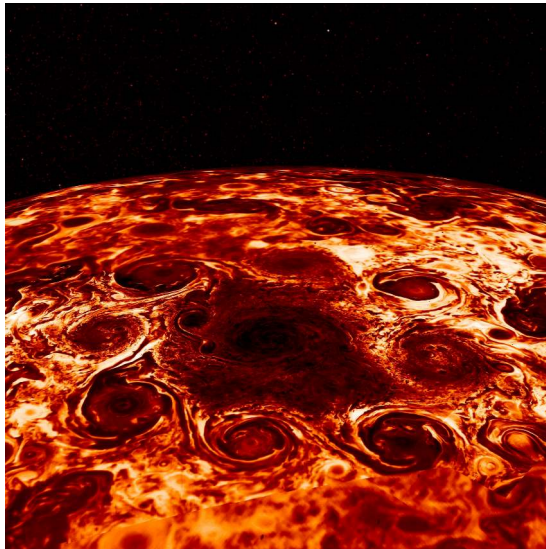
# Jupiter: the Great Red Spot

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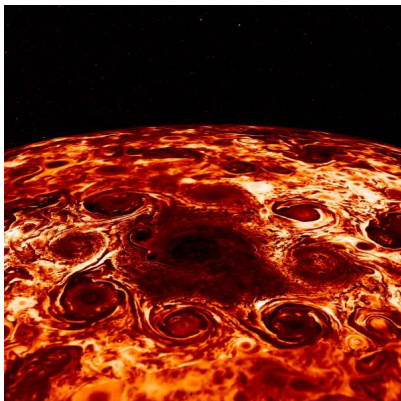
Credit: NASA/JPL-Caltech/SwRI/MSSS (Juno)

- **Largest storm in the solar system**
- Anticyclonic vortex, larger than Earth
- Winds:  $\sim 120 \text{ m s}^{-1}$  at periphery
- First telescopic sightings 1664–65 (possibly a different spot); uninterrupted records since  $\sim 1830$
- Confined between two opposing zonal jets
- Sustained by absorbing smaller vortices + deep  $\text{H}_2\text{O}$  latent heat
- Slowly **shrinking** over the past century



Jupiter's north-polar cyclone cluster from JIRAM, Juno's infrared imager. Credit: NASA/JPL-Caltech/SwRI/ASI/INAF.

## Polar order instead of polar chaos

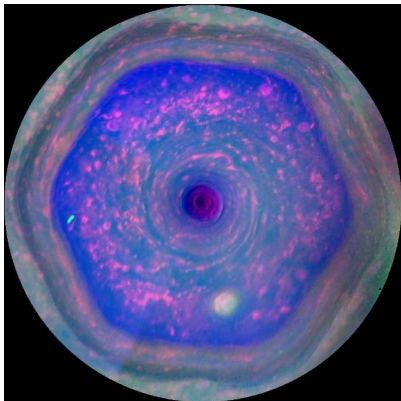


- Eight cyclones ring a central one at Jupiter's north pole; five ring the south pole.
- The clusters have stayed in place over years of Juno perijoves (closest-approach flybys): no merging, no drifting apart.
- A sixth southern cyclone appeared in late 2019 and dissipated within about two months (Mura et al. 2021).

Stable polygons of cyclones: a regime with no Earth analogue, probing how deep rotating convection organises itself.

## Saturn: the hexagonal jet stream

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Credit: NASA/JPL-Caltech/SSI (Cassini, 2013)

- Persistent hexagonal pattern at  $\sim 78^\circ\text{N}$
- Diameter:  $\sim 30,000$  km ( $>$  Earth's diameter)
- First seen in the Voyager flyby images (1980–81), imaged by Cassini
- Explained as a stable **Rossby wave** with six-fold symmetry
- Resonance between jet speed, width, and Coriolis gradient

Saturn also has periodic **Great White Storms** ( $\sim$ every 30 yr; last: 2010).





Neptune's Great Dark Spot, Voyager 2 (1989). Credit: NASA/JPL-Caltech.

## Neptune: extreme weather on a cold world

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- Receives only  $\sim 1/900$ th of Earth's solar flux
- Yet has the **fastest winds** in the solar system:  $\sim 580 \text{ m s}^{-1}$
- Voyager 2 (1989): Great Dark Spot (since vanished), new storms formed
- Storms more transient than Jupiter's

Neptune radiates  $\sim 2.6\times$  more energy than it receives from the Sun. Internal heat (gravitational contraction) drives convection and storms even with negligible solar heating.

A powerful reminder that solar flux alone does not determine weather.



## **7. Climate evolution & the faint young Sun**

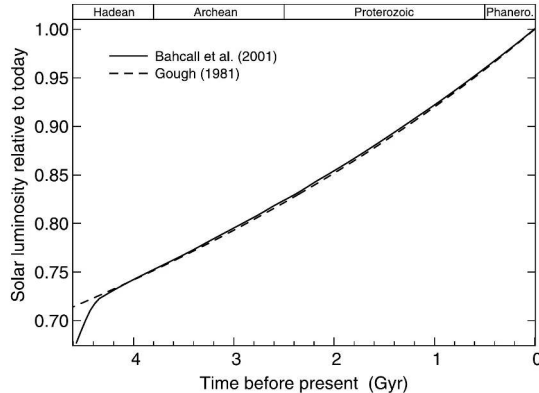
## Solar luminosity evolution

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The Sun brightens as  $H \rightarrow He$  increases the core mean molecular weight:

$$\frac{L(t)}{L_{\odot}} \approx \left[ 1 + \frac{2}{5} \left( 1 - \frac{t}{t_{\odot}} \right) \right]^{-1}$$

- $t_{\odot} \approx 4.57$  Gyr (present age of the Sun)
- At formation ( $t = 0$ ):  $L/L_{\odot} \approx 0.71$
- The early Sun was ~**30% fainter** than today
- Even 4 Ga: still ~25% fainter



**Figure 1.** Evolution of solar luminosity over the four geologic eons for the standard solar model described in *Bahcall et al.* [2001] (solid line) and according to the approximation formula [*Gough*, 1981] (dashed line) given in equation (1).

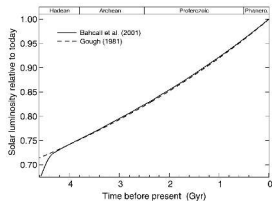
Solar luminosity across the geologic eons. Reproduced from Feulner (2012).

# Reading the faint-young-Sun curve

RG2006

FEUENR: THE FAINT YOUNG SUN PROBLEM

RG2006



**Figure 1.** Evolution of solar luminosity over the four geologic eons for the standard solar model described in Bahcall et al. [2001] (solid line) and according to the approximation formula [Gough, 1981] (dashed line) given in equation (1).

- The standard solar model and Gough's analytic formula agree to ~0.1% over the past 4 Gyr.
- At the start of the Archean the Sun was ~25% fainter: with today's greenhouse, Earth would have been frozen.
- The eon labels along the top tie the luminosity curve to the geological record: liquid water is inferred throughout.

The Sun brightened by a third over Earth's lifetime, yet the sedimentary record never freezes over. Something compensated.

## The faint young Sun paradox

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A 30% fainter Sun  $\rightarrow T_{\text{eff}} \approx 255 \times (0.71)^{1/4} \approx 234 \text{ K}$

With a modern greenhouse: surface well below freezing  $\rightarrow$  **frozen ocean**.

But the geological record says otherwise:

- **Zircon crystals** (4.4 Ga):  $\delta^{18}\text{O}$  ratios require liquid water
- **Pillow basalts and sedimentary rocks** (3.8 Ga): formed underwater
- **Stromatolites** (3.5 Ga): microbial mats requiring warm liquid water

Faint Sun should have frozen Earth, but geological evidence demands liquid water for >4 Gyr. This is the **faint young Sun paradox** (Sagan & Mullen, 1972).

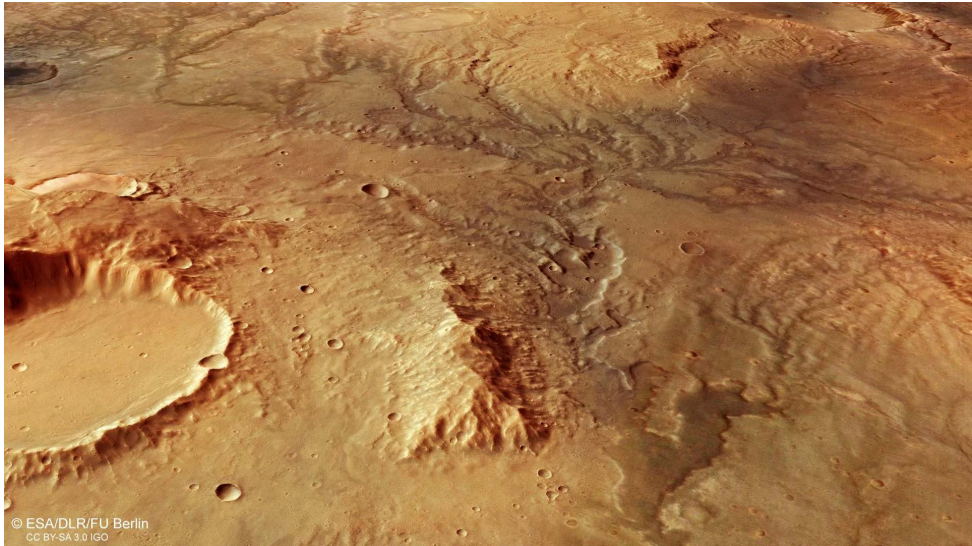
## Possible solutions

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- **Enhanced CO<sub>2</sub> greenhouse:** 10–1000× more CO<sub>2</sub> than today  
Plausible: less exposed continental area, so the weathering thermostat settles at higher CO<sub>2</sub>
- **Methane greenhouse:** Biogenic CH<sub>4</sub> from early methanogens  
Long-lived in an anoxic (O<sub>2</sub>-free) atmosphere
- **N<sub>2</sub> pressure broadening:** Thicker N<sub>2</sub> atmosphere (2–3× present)  
Enhances CO<sub>2</sub> and H<sub>2</sub>O absorption bands
- **Lower albedo:** Less land area + fewer clouds → absorb more sunlight

Most likely: **combination** of elevated CO<sub>2</sub> and CH<sub>4</sub>, regulated by the carbonate-silicate cycle.





Noachian valley networks, Mars Express HRSC. Credit: ESA/DLR/FU Berlin (G. Neukum).

## The Mars climate puzzle

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Mars at 1.52 AU → less than half of Earth's solar flux. With a faint young Sun: even worse.

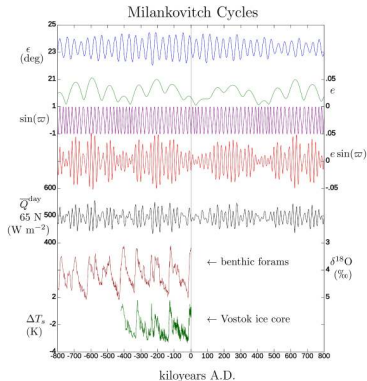
Yet the geological evidence for warm, wet conditions in the Noachian (>3.7 Ga) is strong:

- Extensive valley networks carved by flowing water
- Clay minerals from aqueous weathering
- Sedimentary deposits in ancient lake basins (e.g., Jezero crater)

Dense CO<sub>2</sub> alone is insufficient: it condenses into ice clouds that *increase* albedo.

**Proposed solutions:** Reducing gases (H<sub>2</sub>, CH<sub>4</sub>) from volcanism and water-rock reactions. Early Mars climate remains a **major open problem**.

# Milankovitch cycles: orbital forcing



Credit: Wikimedia, CC BY-SA

- **Obliquity:**  $22.1^\circ$ – $24.5^\circ$  on  $\sim 41$  kyr
- **Eccentricity:**  $e = 0$ – $0.06$  on 100 and 400 kyr
- **Precession:**  $\sim 26$  kyr
- Change seasonal/latitudinal insolation
- Pace glacial-interglacial cycles
- Match  $\delta^{18}\text{O}$  in ocean sediments

Source: Hays et al. (1976); Laskar et al. (2004)

## Climate feedbacks

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Climate stability depends on feedback mechanisms:

**Ice-albedo feedback** (positive):

Cooling → ice expands → higher albedo → less absorption → more cooling.

Can trigger **snowball Earth** (Neoproterozoic, ~700 Ma).

**Water vapour feedback** (positive):

Warming → more evaporation →  $H_2O$  is a greenhouse gas → more warming.

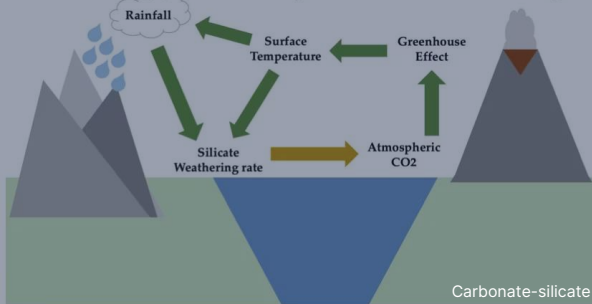
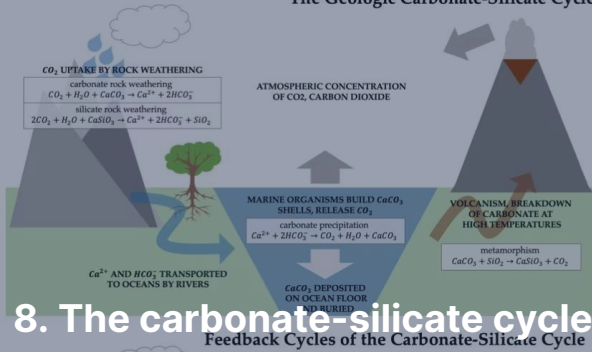
The largest positive feedback: with all feedbacks,  $CO_2$  doubling warms ~3 K vs. ~1.2 K without. If runaway: **Venus scenario**.

**Cloud feedback** (complex):

Low clouds: reflect sunlight (cooling). High cirrus: trap IR (warming).

Net effect: largest uncertainty in climate models.

## The Geologic Carbonate-Silicate Cycle



## The Urey reaction

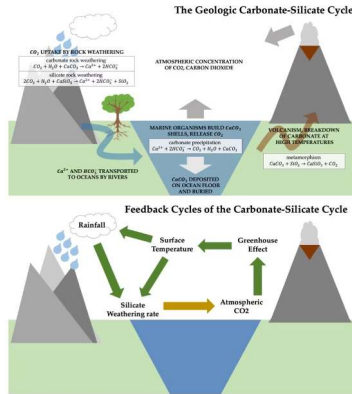
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Silicate weathering by atmospheric CO<sub>2</sub> dissolved in rainwater:



- CO<sub>2</sub> dissolves in rain → weak acid
- Acid reacts with silicate minerals at the surface
- Products: limestone (CaCO<sub>3</sub>) and silica (SiO<sub>2</sub>)
- Transported by rivers to the ocean → deposited as sediment
- Net effect: **draws** CO<sub>2</sub> **out of the atmosphere** (carbon sink)

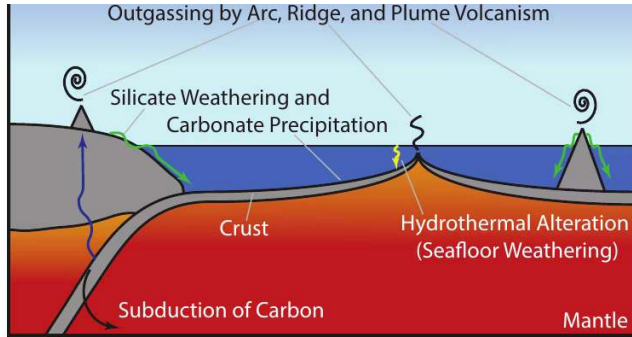
# Volcanic outgassing: the carbon source



Credit: Wikimedia, CC BY-SA 4.0

- **Plate tectonics** closes the cycle
- Carbonate ocean floor is subducted into the mantle
- High  $T$  and  $P$  decompose carbonates  $\rightarrow$  release  $\text{CO}_2$
- $\text{CO}_2$  returned to the atmosphere via **volcanic outgassing**
- This is the long-term carbon **source**

The cycle balances sink (weathering) against source (volcanism).

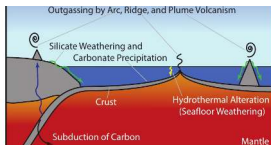


**Figure 6.** Schematic diagram of the carbonate–silicate cycle as it operates on the modern-day, plate tectonic Earth. Adapted from Foley (2015), Foley and Driscoll (2016).

The carbonate-silicate cycle on the plate-tectonic Earth. Reproduced from Foley (2024).



# Sources and sinks of the thermostat



**Figure 6.** Schematic diagram of the carbonate-silicate cycle as it operates on the modern-day, plate tectonic Earth. Adapted from Foley (2015), Foley and Driscoll (2016).

- Sources: arc, ridge, and plume volcanism return  $\text{CO}_2$  from the mantle and from subducted carbonates.
- Sinks: silicate weathering and carbonate burial, with seafloor weathering as a secondary sink.
- Warmer climate  $\rightarrow$  faster weathering  $\rightarrow$   $\text{CO}_2$  drawdown  $\rightarrow$  cooling; response time  $\sim 0.5$  Myr.

A closed loop through atmosphere, ocean, crust, and mantle: break any link (Venus, Mars) and the thermostat fails.

# The negative feedback thermostat

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Weathering rate depends strongly on temperature (Arrhenius-type):

1. **Planet warms:**

More rainfall + faster reactions → weathering increases  
→ more  $\text{CO}_2$  removed → greenhouse weakens → **cools down**

2. **Planet cools:**

Less rainfall + slower reactions → weathering decreases  
→ volcanic  $\text{CO}_2$  accumulates → greenhouse strengthens → **warms up**

This thermostat operates on ~0.5 Myr timescales. It is the primary reason Earth has maintained habitable temperatures for >4 Gyr despite a 30% increase in solar luminosity.

## Venus & Mars: failed thermostats

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The cycle requires **liquid water** (to weather rocks) and **active volcanism** (to recycle carbon):

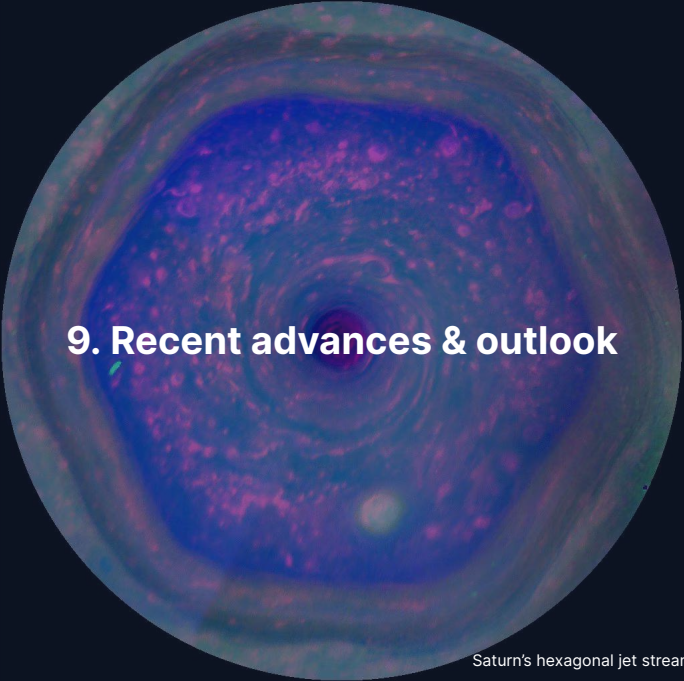
### Venus:

- Lost surface water (runaway greenhouse + H escape)
- No water → no silicate weathering
- Volcanic CO<sub>2</sub> accumulated unchecked
- Result: 92 bar CO<sub>2</sub> atmosphere

### Mars:

- Interior cooled, volcanism ceased (~3 Ga)
- No volcanic CO<sub>2</sub> source
- Remaining CO<sub>2</sub> drawn down by weathering + lost to space
- Result: thin 6 mbar atmosphere

Habitability requires not just the right temperature, but the right **geological activity** to sustain it over billions of years.

A circular image of Saturn's atmosphere showing a prominent hexagonal jet stream. The hexagon is composed of six distinct, parallel bands of light and dark colors, creating a hexagonal shape in the center. The colors range from deep blue to light blue and white. The hexagon is surrounded by a darker, more turbulent atmosphere. The overall image has a grainy, high-contrast appearance typical of space imagery.

## 9. Recent advances & outlook

Saturn's hexagonal jet stream. Credit: NASA/JPL-Caltech/SSI

## The runaway greenhouse

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A planet that absorbs too much stellar flux can lose its oceans entirely.

- Water vapour is a strong greenhouse gas
- Warmer surface → more evaporation → more greenhouse → hotter surface
- Outgoing longwave radiation asymptotes to  $\sim 280\text{--}310 \text{ W/m}^2$  (Simpson-Nakajima limit)
- If absorbed stellar flux exceeds this, the positive feedback is unstoppable
- Oceans fully evaporate;  $\text{H}_2\text{O}$  photolysed by UV; H escapes hydrodynamically
- End state: dry,  $\text{CO}_2$ -rich atmosphere (Venus today)

Source: Nakajima et al. (1992); Goldblatt et al. (2013)

## Ice-albedo feedback: the ultimate amplifier

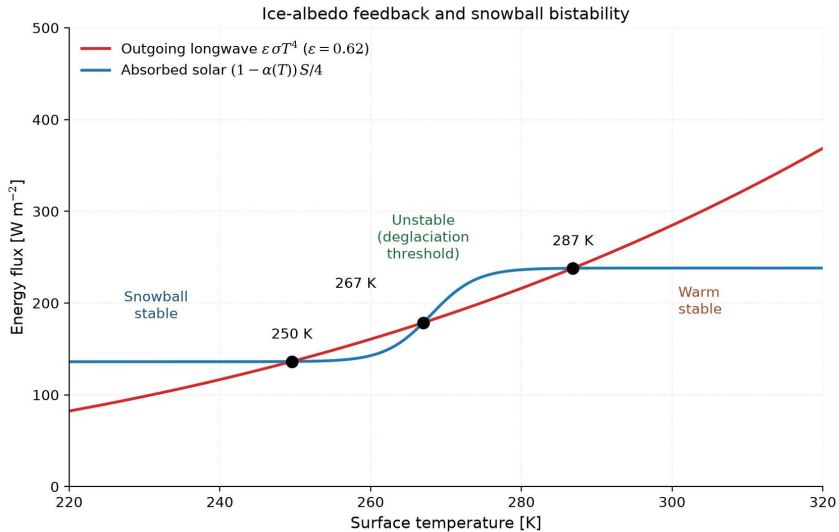
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A positive feedback loop that can destabilise climate:

$T$  drops  $\rightarrow$  ice cover grows  $\rightarrow$  albedo rises  $\rightarrow$  less solar absorption  $\rightarrow T$  drops further

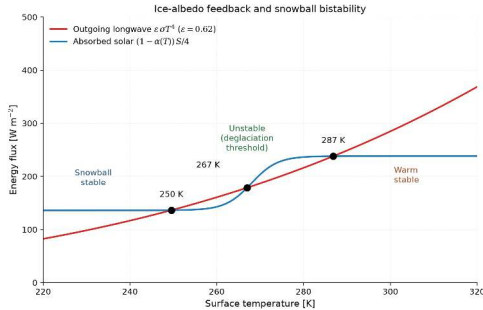
- Ice and snow reflect ~60–90% of incident sunlight vs. ~10–30% for ocean and land
- For Earth: the feedback is strong enough to create a **tipping point**
- If the ice line advances to ~30° latitude (about half the surface area), the feedback runs away
- Runaway cooling then drives the planet into a **snowball state**
- On modern Earth the same feedback amplifies polar warming (Arctic amplification), far from the runaway threshold

Source: Pierrehumbert (2010); North et al. (1981)



Energy-balance bistability of the ice-albedo feedback. Course figure.

# Reading the bistability diagram



- Red: outgoing longwave  $\epsilon\sigma T^4$ ; blue: absorbed sunlight, with albedo stepping from 0.3 (ice-free) to 0.6 (ice-covered).
- Three crossings: a stable snowball at 250 K, an unstable threshold at 267 K, a stable warm state at 287 K.
- Push the climate past the middle crossing and the feedback carries it the rest of the way, in either direction.

Same Sun, two stable Earths: which one you get depends on where you start.



# Snowball Earth

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Credit: Wikimedia Commons, public domain

- Earth may have gone through **two snowball states** in the Neoproterozoic (~717 and 635 Ma)
- Triggered by ice-albedo runaway when the ice line reaches ~30° latitude
- Surface temperatures drop below -50°C
- Volcanic CO<sub>2</sub> accumulates over ~10–100 Myr
- Greenhouse overwhelms albedo; ice melts rapidly
- Correlated with the rise of complex life shortly afterward

Source: Hoffman & Schrag (2002); Pierrehumbert et al. (2011)

## Venus's super-rotation: thermal tides

---

How does Venus's atmosphere rotate 60 times faster than the surface?

- Surface rotation: 243 days, retrograde
- Cloud-top winds: 4 days, ~100 m/s
- Sustaining this requires angular momentum transport **upward and equatorward**
- **Thermal tides:** solar heating of the cloud layer creates day-night pressure gradients, which launch waves that carry angular momentum upward
- **Planetary-scale waves** redistribute angular momentum toward the equator
- Detailed mechanism still debated; Akatsuki measurements ongoing

Source: Sánchez-Lavega et al. (2017)

## Quantifying the weathering feedback

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A simple model for the carbonate-silicate thermostat:

$$W(T) = W_0 \exp\left(\frac{T - T_0}{T_e}\right)$$

where  $W$  is the weathering rate,  $T_e \approx 10$  K is the  $e$ -folding temperature.

- Doubling weathering requires  $\sim 7$  K warming
- Halving it requires  $\sim 7$  K cooling
- In steady state,  $W = V$  (volcanism) sets atmospheric  $p\text{CO}_2$
- Perturbation analysis: climate damping timescale  $\sim 0.5$  Myr
- Works only if liquid water and active volcanism coexist

Source: Walker et al. (1981); Pierrehumbert (2010)

## The Venus phosphine debate

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In 2020, a team reported tentative detection of phosphine ( $\text{PH}_3$ ) in Venus's clouds.

- Greaves et al. (2021): ~20 ppb  $\text{PH}_3$  at 53–60 km altitude
- No known abiotic source in Venus's atmosphere could explain this abundance
- Sparked biological speculation: could  $\text{PH}_3$  be produced by hypothetical Venusian microbes?
- Subsequent reanalyses: signal much weaker or absent (Villanueva et al. 2021); mesospheric  $\text{SO}_2$  reproduces the feature (Lincowski et al. 2021)
- Current status: unconfirmed, controversial
- Motivated new Venus missions: DAVINCI (NASA), EnVision (ESA), VERITAS (NASA)

Source: Greaves et al. (2021), *Nat. Astron.*; Villanueva et al. (2021)

## Dragonfly: a rotorcraft for Titan

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NASA's Dragonfly (launch 2028, arrival 2034) will explore Titan's surface.

- Nuclear-powered rotorcraft, the first of its kind for planetary exploration
- Mass: ~450 kg; can fly ~10 km between science stops
- Will land in the Selk impact crater region
- Sampling organic-rich dunes for mass spectrometry
- Investigating prebiotic chemistry: does the combination of complex organics and transient impact-melt water produce biomolecules?
- 2.7 year primary mission, visiting 20+ sites

Source: Barnes et al. (2021), *PSJ*

## JWST: weather on distant worlds

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JWST is transforming our view of exoplanet atmospheres.

- WASP-39 b: first clear detection of CO<sub>2</sub> in an exoplanet atmosphere (2022), then SO<sub>2</sub> from photochemistry (2023)
- WASP-107 b: SO<sub>2</sub> and silicate cloud signatures (2024)
- Phase curves map dayside-to-nightside heat redistribution on hot Jupiters
- Measurements of terminator cloudiness (east-west asymmetry)
- Searching for weather patterns, circulation signatures
- First steps toward characterising habitable-zone rocky planet atmospheres

Source: The JWST Transiting Exoplanet Community ERS Team (2023)

## Recent advances: early Mars climate

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- Updated 3D climate models with reducing gases ( $\text{H}_2$ ,  $\text{CH}_4$ ) can warm early Mars
- Collision-induced  $\text{H}_2$ - $\text{CO}_2$  absorption is a strong greenhouse at high  $\text{CO}_2$  pressures (Wordsworth et al. 2017)
- Impact-triggered warming events: large impactors deliver heat and deflect vapour into the atmosphere
- Localised glaciation models: the “icy highlands” picture
- Episodic vs. sustained warming: still debated
- Perseverance (Jezero crater, 2021–) investigating the aqueous record

Source: Wordsworth (2016); Wordsworth et al. (2017)

## Summary

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1. Clouds form when rising air cools past the **saturation vapour pressure** at the LCL
2. The Clausius-Clapeyron equation gives  $P_{\text{sat}}(T) \propto \exp(-L_v/R_v T)$ ; governs all clouds
3. Cloud species vary:  $\text{H}_2\text{O}$  (Earth),  $\text{H}_2\text{SO}_4$  (Venus),  $\text{NH}_3/\text{H}_2\text{O}$  layers (Jupiter)
4. Atmospheric circulation: Hadley cells, Coriolis deflection, jet streams
5. Rotation rate sets number of circulation cells (1 on Venus, 3 on Earth, ~15 on Jupiter)
6. Weather: Mars dust storms, Venus super-rotation, Jupiter GRS, Saturn hexagon
7. Faint young Sun paradox: early Sun 30% fainter, yet Earth had liquid water
8. Carbonate-silicate cycle: Earth's climate thermostat; failed on Venus and Mars



## Looking ahead to Lecture 7

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- Three lectures treated planets from the top down: energy budgets, vertical structure, and now clouds, winds, and climate.
- Lecture 7 turns to the solid surfaces beneath: impact craters as chronometers, volcanism and tectonics from within, erosion and weathering from above.
- The climate story returns as geology: Mars's valley networks become a record to read, not only a puzzle to solve.

## Questions?

Next: Lecture 7, Planetary surfaces: geology, geomorphology & geophysics

Mon 28 Sep, 15:00–17:00, room 5419.0161 (Collegezaal)

Next tutorial: Fri 25 Sep, 13:00–15:00, room 5419.0161 (Collegezaal)

<https://ips.formingworlds.space>